

magazine



backpage
Sunhil Sippy's *Eastward*
reveals a raw Mumbai

GO TO » PAGE 8

WIDE ANGLE
Column | Have you ever
been 'canceled'?

GO TO » PAGE 6

LITERARY REVIEW
Turning the 'tradwife'
fantasy on its head

GO TO » PAGE 2

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DOMESTIC COOKS OF THE DIGITAL AGE

With employers choosing video links over family recipes, kitchen helpers are learning global flavours from YouTube and Reels — upskilling themselves and asking for better pay



Moni Bibi Khan learns from a video recipe; and (right) Tulsi. (SUDHAKARA JAIN, PRATIMA CHABBI)

Pratima Chabbi

Didi, what should I make tomorrow?" Tulsi calls out, untying the dupatta knotted around her waist while cooking. This is a customary question before she leaves for the day. "I'll message you later," replies her employer Komal Shah, 37, a marketing professional.

Tulsi, 26, relocated from Nepal to Bengaluru seven years ago. Now, she cooks at three houses daily, spending at least a couple of hours in each. That evening, Shah sends her a WhatsApp voice note and a link, asking, "Can we make this tomorrow?" The link is for a

YouTube recipe video on *bisi bele bath*, a spicy rice dish from Karnataka that Tulsi has never heard of. "The name itself is challenging," she says. She watches the video between dinner and chores, and again while walking to Shah's house the next morning.

In the kitchen, Tulsi props her phone against a steel *dabba* and hits play. As a voice lists the ingredients, she pauses the video, gathers the vegetables and spices, and then presses play again. This is her new normal. "My WhatsApp has more cooking links than anything else," she jokes, naming at least 10 dishes — from a Greek tomato and feta salad, to a Keralan *avial* and an Italian marinara pasta — that

she's attempted in the last three months. She follows a cooking video at least three times a week. "When someone stands beside you, there's pressure. With a video, if something isn't perfect, you can fix it the next time," she adds.

Tulsi's *bisi bele bath* reveals a bigger change happening across India's kitchens. Recipes that once used to be shared with domestic cooks through in-person lessons, handwritten notes, TV shows and hours spent cooking together, now come as WhatsApp links, Instagram Reels, and YouTube videos.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGES 4-5**



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UNPACKING THE 'TRADWIFE' FANTASY

Dystopian thriller *Yesteryear* is already creating movie buzz and boasts a tantalising premise, but leaves many of its compelling concerns underexplored

Suvrat Arora

What happens when a performance is brutally stripped of its audience? Natalie Heller Mills, the epitome of what a traditional domestic Christian woman ought to be, is simply “perfect at being alive”. Until the camera turns off.

Caro Claire Burke’s *Yesteryear* cracks open the fractured, dual existence of its anti-heroine, Natalie. The narrative ruthlessly ricochets between her performed pastoral ideal – raising six children, tending a homestead, and catering to a cowboy husband for her millions of social media followers – and the invisible infrastructure that sustains it: a rotating cast of nannies, producers, workers, and the cold, modern luxuries that actually underwrite her organic paradise.

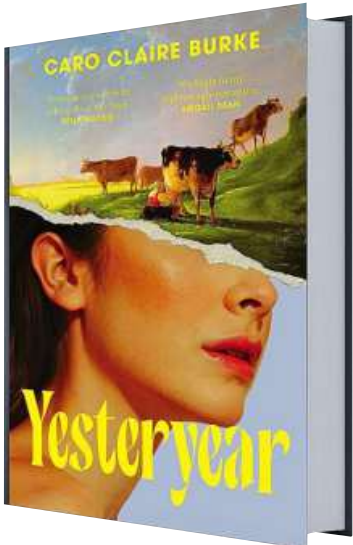
Burke’s debut dystopian thriller offers a scrumptious hit of schadenfreude, marooning its protagonist on the cusp of collapse. The twist is absolute: Natalie wakes up one day to the very agrarian life she marketed, only to find herself trapped in the unglamorous, exhausting reality of 1855. Little wonder that such a delectable plotline has already been optioned for a film adaptation, reportedly starring Anne Hathaway. Unfortunately, this attention-arresting premise is

also the novel’s greatest achievement.

Impeccably attuned to the zeitgeist, the book serves as a jarring reminder of the vanity, insecurity and disorder that churn beneath the veneer of perfectly curated digital lives. It also captures how everyday living increasingly becomes performative, and how the burden of maintaining an image can come to eclipse the self beneath it. Equally compelling is the narrative’s engagement with the question of children’s consent, probing the ethics of turning childhood into content for public consumption.

Missed opportunities

The novel depicts a brittle performance of womanhood through its wickedly flawed protagonist, who disparages the very idea of feminism and retreats into a romanticised vision of a Christian, nationalist Americana – one rooted in submission. “America hates women. What a comfort to remember,” Natalie remarks. Sheltered in her conviction that she has unlocked the only true version of happiness for women, Natalie fashions herself as the “mother every woman wanted to be” – raising children on organic living and Christian values – and the “wife every man wanted to come home to”: the perfect homemaker, gestating children in abundance.



Yesteryear
Caro Claire Burke
Fourth Estate
₹599

Anyone hurling invective at her way of life is dismissed as an “Angry Woman” – part of a chorus of bitter, envious women angry that they haven’t chosen her life.

The book approaches motherhood with a refreshing lack of sentimentality. Is it possible for a mother to dislike her own child? Natalie does. The early chapters render postpartum depression and the uneasy process of becoming a mother with remarkable honesty. But the same dilutes into cursory mentions of breastfeeding struggles and birth choices as the plot propels forward.

This flattening extends to the children themselves. Though central to the plot, they remain largely caricaturish and one-dimensional. “I rarely paid attention to the differences in the children,” Natalie confesses.

Although Natalie’s father-in-law is a politician running for office, politics remains curiously underexplored in the novel. It functions less as a subject of enquiry than as a convenient plot device. For a novel so invested in questions of gender, power and American identity, this absence of political engagement feels like a significant missed opportunity.

Alternating timelines

Ultimately, Natalie is a deeply layered, even more deeply flawed, and occasionally funny character. Yet, we rarely see this Harvard dropout’s wits at play. Instead, her ascent is shaped less by ingenuity than by fortune. She marries the youngest son of a political dynasty and uses his family’s wealth to build the Yesteryear ranch, where Caleb can perform the fantasy of the rugged cowboy. Later, another stroke of luck delivers to her millions of Instagram followers. The result is a character whose convictions are endlessly scrutinised, but whose intellect is seldom put on display.

The alternating timelines of the present day and the 1850s converge in a deftly executed final twist, but the revelation comes at a cost. In steering towards its destination, the novel leaves behind several of its most compelling concerns, exchanging thematic depth for narrative momentum.

Burke’s debut novel is a work of tantalising beginnings. *Yesteryear* sets countless hares running, only to lose sight of them in the chase – transforming what might have been sharp, incisive social commentary into an entertaining and absorbing page-turner. In the end, it peels back the influencer fantasy we so often romanticise, but stops short of fully exploring the deeper questions it raises.

The reviewer is an independent writer based in Bengaluru.

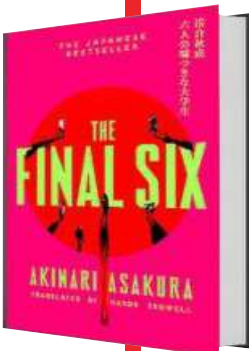
ONE FOR THE ROAD

Turning point

All about the choices that define us and the stories we tell ourselves

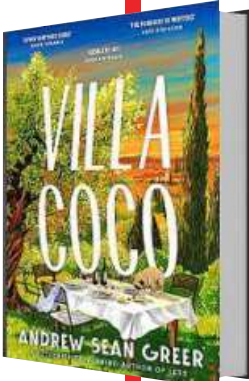
Swati Daftuar

What do a ruthless corporate competition, a multigenerational family saga and stories of queer love have in common? More than you might think. This Pride Month, the reading list brings together characters navigating ambition, love, loss and reinvention, proving that some of the most riveting stories emerge when people are forced to confront who they are – and who they want to become.



The Final Six | Akinari Asakura, trs Haydn Trowell

Nothing is as satisfying as a locked-room mystery done right, and Asakura gives the familiar trope a distinctly contemporary twist in his “runaway Japanese bestseller”. *The Final Six* follows six applicants competing for the same position at an elite tech company. But envelopes containing damaging secrets about each candidate threaten to derail not just careers but entire lives. Tense and psychologically sharp, the story works both as a survival thriller and a critique of corporate culture. (Sphere; ₹599)



Villa Coco | Andrew Sean Greer

Greer’s latest is a delightfully strange Tuscan comedy. A young American archivist arrives at a crumbling villa to catalogue its treasures and is quickly swept into the orbit of the imperious 92-year-old Baronessa Lisabetta. Like Greer’s bestselling *Less*, this novel too is witty, humane and quietly queer; a tender meditation on ageing, friendship and the many forms love can take. (Sceptre; ₹699)



I'll Take the Fire | Leïla Slimani, trs Sam Taylor

The final volume of Slimani’s trilogy and the most autobiographical instalment of the lot, the novel draws on the French-Moroccan author’s own family history. The story follows the third generation of the Belhaj family, focusing on sisters Mia and Inès. Moving between Casablanca, Paris and London, it blends family saga with an intimate exploration of identity, exile and freedom. Mia’s struggle to resist convention and claim a queer selfhood gives the novel its emotional force. (Faber & Faber; ₹389 [ebook])

People We Love | Preeti Shenoy

In this collection of three interconnected stories, Shenoy circles a deceptively simple question: how do you know whether the life you’ve built is the right one? Through the backstories of some of her well-loved characters from previous novels, the author explores love, timing, friendship, and the choices that continue to echo long after they are made. Shenoy combines emotional instinct with a warmer, ensemble-driven structure, making this an easy, engaging read. (HarperCollins India; ₹399)

Homo and Juliet | Shruti Chakravarty

Presenting eight real-life queer love stories, *Homo and Juliet* asks a larger question: what happens to love when the scripts we inherit for intimacy, marriage and family do not fit? In her introduction, Chakravarty argues that queer relationships often require people to invent their own languages of commitment, belonging and partnership. The stories that follow, including Chakravarty’s own, find their best moments in the details: a chance meeting on the steps of a university, a proposal note written a day before the erstwhile Section 377 was read down, and lovers finding their way back after marriage, violence, silence... (Yoda Press; ₹699)

(A monthly column on popular fiction.)

The writer is an independent journalist, editor, and literary curator.

Vasudevan Mukunth
mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in

Eka Kurniawan’s new novella, *The Dog Meows, the Cat Barks*, is about a boy who refuses to become what his father insists he is. So when the time comes for him to be someone, his self-pity and anger goad him into recklessness.

Sato Reang has a happy childhood in a small Indonesian town, playing with his friends and roaming the fields, until the day he is circumcised and his father declares he must now become a pious boy. Sato has no choice in the matter. He must pray on time, fast during Ramadan, fear god, and renounce all of life’s little pleasures. He consumes this spiritual curriculum without absorbing, recites the *Quran* without understanding the Arabic, and his father cannot tell the difference. This is the book’s first joke.

While Kurniawan the writer has

been interested in Indonesia’s historical traumas, *The Dog Meows* is about the household rather than the nation. The political is paternal, with Sato’s father failing to see the difference between obedience and faith and going so far as to take a machete to Sato Reang’s beloved plastic ball.

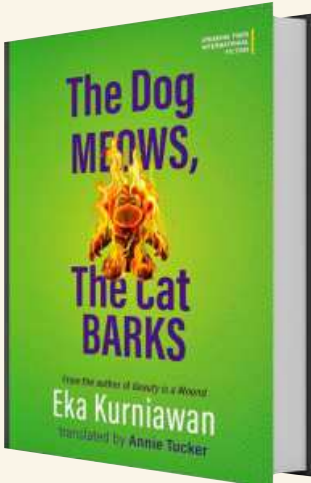
Sometimes, Sato narrates himself as “I” and, at other times, observes himself from the outside as “Sato Reang”. This device does not always

capture Sato’s dissociation – too subtle or fleeting sometimes – but its message is clear. Sato is forced to perform a self he does not recognise, and he learns eventually to see that performed self as another. “Sato Reang eats his fill.” “Sato Reang isn’t sure whether he should burn down the market or the school.”

After his father dies, Sato’s once private rebellion becomes physical and outward, reminiscent of his

Eka Kurniawan’s novella argues that
authoritarianism begins at home

Political is paternal



The Dog Meows, The Cat Barks
Eka Kurniawan, trs Annie Tucker
Speaking Tiger
₹499

father. The father tried to be a writer but failed, and his achievements amounted mostly to his work with a local mosque.

The captive self

This is one of the most common human stories: the thwarted self that thwarts outwards. What a man cannot become, he instructs his children to be. Sato’s father also does not impose religion on his son out of pure faith. When he expects his son must pray five times a day, he also ensures where his son will be five times a day and where he can go from there. This, from a man who lost his own way.

The idea should be familiar to anyone raised in the Indian middle class, where children are expected foremost to live life to a steady beat: examinations, the right ranks, the right sequence of institutions to attend, the right degrees to obtain, starting a family, buying a house, and so on. It

operates in a Mumbai flat where an engineering syllabus is laid out before the child can read and in a Chennai household where a girl’s marriage prospects are read into her report card. The cost of failure is always high, which means that no failure, no deviation from this preordained path, is too small.

Kurniawan renders without editorialising that this kind of ‘love’ has no room for the loved one. Sato never gets to find out who he might have been. Annie Tucker’s translation of the novel is swift, and commendable for staying close to Kurniawan and Sato throughout its 162 pages.

Its ultimate lesson is timeless: Sato’s father and the state in the story’s backdrop share the instinct that the self that cannot be free must ensure no one nearby is free either. Authoritarianism is a political condition but it begins first as a psychological and familial condition.

Daisy Rockwell’s new book playfully explores the art of translation and its attendant weirdness

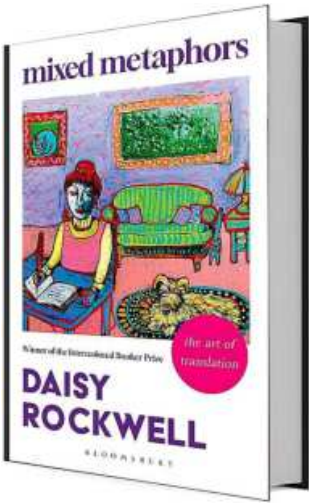
NEITHER FISH NOR FOWL

Anjum Hasan

Just before I laid hands on Daisy Rockwell’s new book, my Swedish husband happened to tell me how the Beatles’ ‘Yesterday’ became a somewhat different product in his language. The word for ‘geese’ is *gäss*, pronounced like the English ‘yes’. And the other two syllables of the refrain, ‘ter’ and ‘day’, sound very similar to the Swedish *te* and *dej*: ‘to’ and ‘you’, respectively. So that classically gloomy song was sung to mean ‘Geese to you, I want to give some geese to you...’ Not quite a translation but still this parodic transporting by the jazz musician who called himself Helmer Byrd is liable to cause transports of delight.

‘To carry across’ is the root meaning of ‘translation’, Rockwell reminds us in *Mixed Metaphors*, which too is often funny about an often contentious subject: literary translations. The slim text is divided into the theory and the practice, as it were. The first half has her casting about for the most apt metaphor for translation and she lays out 22 – in verse.

Now translation is a harmless, homey occupation like building a Lego castle (but without a manual, so improvisations are called for) or replicating a fabric quilt with bits of coloured paper. Now it is innovative, like Ginger Rogers dancing a score Fred Astaire choreographed. Now translation grows daring; the book to be translated is Alice dropping down to Wonderland and her bodily adventures or misadventures are the



Mixed Metaphors
Daisy Rockwell
Bloomsbury
₹499

disfigurements done to the text in the process of making a coherent translation. Now translation turns even more bizarre: it’s Dr. Frankenstein’s monster; the translator has succeeded in bringing to life the thing she was patching together. “And the screams the monster is greeted/with as it lurches through the streets,/those are the screams of people who find/translation fishy/inaccurate/unnatural.”

Linguistic monoculture
Rockwell stays playful even when she brings up serious points. One is about the dominating English language, something she can’t help – being herself a prolific and celebrated translator from Hindi and Urdu into English – but an issue she



can illustrate. She renders it a “monocrop”, invasive, bland, and ingested by billions. “English is the potato crop for McDonald’s french fries, the corn crop for corn oil and corn syrup [...] The British Empire spread the English monocrop initially, but the American Empire is the greatest expert on the export of the processed and the packaged, the canned and the bottled, the I-can’t-believe-it’s-not-real.”

Booker effect
Yet in the much narrower literary realm, one assumes that translation into the language has done it some good, if only because it continues to complicate the idea of what English literature is. Although Rockwell characterises literary translation as “maligned” and “decadent”, interest in it seems to be growing. Just one example is the International Booker Prize, which from 2016, has been awarding translated fiction. (She and Geetanjali Shree jointly won it in

2022 for *Tomb of Sand*.) The book’s second, more personal, half has a section called ‘Five Hair-Raising Copyright Tales’ – on the hazards of translation. (It’s even more enjoyable if one knows Rockwell’s bibliography and can decode the identities of these figures, discreetly named after the Urdu alphabets.) Two utterly different worlds collide in these anecdotes. On the one hand are celebrated Hindi and Urdu writers from a generation on its last legs, or who have recently departed, who have had an informal, to put it mildly, approach to the publication, translation, and ownership of their

International Booker Prize-winning translator Daisy Rockwell. (GETTY IMAGES)

work. On the other hand is a professional (most of the time) English-language publishing industry seeking to bring some order to the field. One thinks of the hapless Deven in Anita Desai’s *In Custody*, bent on trying to pin down that magnificent, decayed, and utterly elusive Urdu poet, Nur.

Hunting for metaphors
Mixed Metaphors comes with Rockwell’s own drawings, delightfully odd. Her composites of people, creatures, objects and, again, Urdu characters, make one wonder if the whole business of translation is neither fish nor fowl, a strangely anomalous something. But having understood that, why do we need so many metaphors for it? “It is fashionable nowadays to push the boundaries of our definitions of what translation is, as though sitting still for hours on end, day after day, surrounded by dictionaries, painfully refashioning a new text from an old one is just too boring...” is her explanation. I think too that a performative quality has come to be attached to translating, hence the question each time of what exactly one is doing and the new fashion in metaphor hunting.

Rockwell’s even-handedness is the best thing about this book and about her stance on translation in general. She sees the politics implicit in who is translating what into which language, yet she does not fetishise cultural difference nor give in to the cult of ‘untranslatability’. And one comes away from *Mixed Metaphors* feeling that for all translation’s propensity for errors and even its descent into weirdness, this wanting to see what the ‘carrying over’ reads, sounds, or looks like is simply unkillable human curiosity. To know more than one language is to want to translate.

The reviewer’s forthcoming book is Hometown: Shillong in the World.



Anish Gawande

I hate anthologies. At their best, they can seem like rushed projects rooted in the allure of shared labour, producing a book that can quickly be “brought to the market.” At their most dangerous, however, anthologies – and particularly the anthologisation of queerness – can mobilise the inherent, quiet violence in the act of gathering into a sinister project. They take the sprawling mess of human existence and bind it in neat paper, asking to be read as representative.

As a result, I approached *Queer India Now* with seasoned scepticism. Yet, the volume of 29 piercing pieces that cut across genres proved to be an exquisite ambush. Edited by journalists Dhamini Ratnam and Dhrubo Jyoti, it emerged as a generous, eclectic volume that dismantles the idea of a monolithic queer experience, with surprises on nearly every page.

Between rage and consolation
Resisting the temptation to read with any semblance of order, I flipped the pages to arrive at brilliant, jarring juxtapositions. I was thrust from Prathyush Parasuraman’s titillating, delightfully raunchy ‘In Our Own Image’ straight into the devastating restraint of Vasavi Kalluru’s ‘Bedrooms’, enraged by the former and profoundly consoled by the latter. I found myself reflecting upon trans actor Bonita Rajpurohit’s unvarnished account of the precarity of finding work while resonating with Priya Dali’s pastel-hued illustrations of the life of Disha Pinky Shaikh, the pioneering trans spokesperson for the Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi, a political party in Maharashtra.



Making of queer kinship

This anthology, edited by two Delhi journalists, is an exquisite ambush that dismantles the idea of a monolithic experience

In Vikram Phukan’s ‘What a Drag!’, I found a history of my immediate world: friends like Shals Mahajan recounting the founding of LABIA (Lesbians and Bisexuals in Action), yacht parties off Colaba, the ferry to Gorai. I was enraged at reading Dr. B. Kiran Nayak’s tryst

with disability and queerness in ‘Our Place in Democracy’ and astonished at the thriftiness of Rabi Raj’s creation of queer collectives with limited resources in ‘Straight Outta Bolangir’. I chuckled away to myself in crowded cafes while imagining Ankur Tangade

explaining the difference between polyamorous and pansexual to her mother (recounted in ‘Some Things I Learnt On Bad Dates’). Where my previously unshaken distrust in anthologies was most visibly transfigured, however, was at The Bookshop in Delhi’s Lodhi Colony. On arriving late, as usual, to a room held enthralled by Jyoti moderating a panel with Vqueeram Aditya Sahai and Kalluru, I encountered the anthology not as a site for the collection of stories but rather for the creation of community. As Jyoti read aloud Sahai’s poem, “Someday, I will be an old woman/ seen by a boy of twenty-nine, wistfully,” shivers ran down my 29-year-old spine. The staccato vignettes of queerness in small-town India, assembled by Jyoti and Dhiren Borisa, came alive in discussions on what parts of the



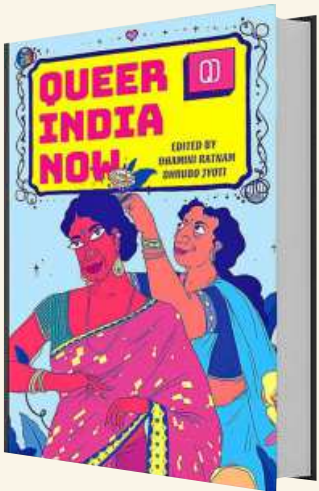
book we had enjoyed most. As the time came to sign our copies, I discovered that anthologies are signed by editors on the title page and by contributors within the index. Sahai took my copy and wrote in it, in place of a flourish, “F*** this, Anish. Read the poet of our times,” meaning Shripad Sinnakaar. In that moment, I felt a fierce claiming of lineage, a mapping of a shared world.

The act of curation
One real reservation surfaced when returning to the introduction by the editors. It is generous and learned, and younger readers will be grateful for it, but where it reaches for grand framing, a history of queerness, a definition of what it

means to be queer today, the recently amended Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, and the long shadow of colonial law, what I most wanted was the story of the book’s own making. How were these pieces found, the contributors chosen? Had they written before, did they all write in English, and what did it mean to set this author beside that one? An anthology assembled with such care left me hungry for the story of its assembly. That evening, lost in thought, I took the wrong bus and ended up at the Hazrat Nizamuddin Dargah. Standing inside, facing Amir Khusrau’s tomb, I listened to a woman wailing her dirge-like *duas* from behind the marble lattice I had my back to. Her words were barely perceptible beneath the chaotic ushering and the laying of chadars, yet for a transcendent moment, I felt I had become the conduit through which her prayers reached their destination. I touched the cool marble, mumbled a small prayer, and walked out into the night with my face wet.

Between two graves I opened ‘Bedrooms’ again, Kalluru’s return to the rooms that have held them, one that “smells like Dettol and unspoken things,” others where friends stayed through the falling apart, where love did not fix them but held them, and in that holding they remained. It was the kinship Ratnam had written of elsewhere in the book, the choosing of one’s own kin. And I wept, for the ones who were not held, for the families of choice stolen from us, for a love that once could not speak its name and that today, luckily for some of us though not yet for all, has at last found its utterance.

The reviewer is a writer, translator, and political spokesperson.



Queer India Now
Ed. Dhamini Ratnam,
Dhrubo Jyoti
Queer Directions
₹599

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

The cooks watch, pause, replay and adapt these recipes, bringing new dishes into different homes and sometimes to their own families. Most dishes they've never seen, let alone tasted, before. But they are enterprising – a cook from Odisha says she's recently learnt *khao suey* from YouTube, another from Siliguri has mastered Turkish eggs. Elsewhere, cooks are trying *shakshuka*, Caesar salad, *thecha* prawns, cold soups, roast chicken, and pesto pasta.

Inside the YouTube kitchen

Moni Bibi Khan, 31, from West Bengal, has lived in Bengaluru since 2019 and worked for Gauri Chhabbi, a 39-year-old banking professional for six years. She remembers when meals were more predictable. "In the first year, *didi* stood with me in the kitchen, opening spice boxes and explaining what's used in everyday Keralan and North Karnataka dishes," says Khan. "She showed me how cooking curry leaves with a pinch of asafoetida creates a rich, savoury tempering." As the family's tastes changed, Khan learnt to cook more dishes. "Now, at least five nights a week, they want something new. Last night, I made chicken *chukkani*, a Nepali dish *didi* had seen on Instagram. This weekend, I will make egg fried rice and garlic vegetable stir-fry, which I'm an expert at now. I even learned stroganoff [the Russian dish usually made



(L-R) Venkateswarulu with Wahida; Nazia in Mumbai; Tezal Thomas in Kochi; and a cook from Jinn, (SUDHANT THAKUR, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

cities. After Devi told her Pune-based employer Malavde about her prowess with YouTube, the latter has recommended her to several employers. This can translate to better pay, too. (Salaries in metros start from ₹5,000 and can go up to ₹15,000.) Mumbai publicist Sudarshan says, "If a cook offers more variety and independence in the kitchen, an extra ₹1,000-₹2,000 is something we happily offer."

Pros and cons Placing this shift within India's informal domestic-work economy, however, reveals several roadblocks. According to Aditi Surie, a sociologist who studies technology, gender, and informal work at the Indian Institute for Human Settlements, "For part-time cooks, digital upskilling can improve employability and gain them a less supervised, more flexible kitchen, but for live-in workers, it could become another unpaid task."

Also, what of workers with keypad phones? Or older workers, cooks with low literacy, and those whose phones are controlled by their husbands or sons? "They are structurally excluded – not because they cannot learn, but because the conditions have not been set up for them to participate on equal terms," says Chowdhury. "So, there are



If a cook offers more variety and independence in the kitchen, an extra ₹1,000-₹2,000 is something we happily offer

AISHWARYA SUDARSHAN
Publicist

both labour-market advantages and disadvantages at this point, and it is important to track both."

Meanwhile, in many homes, videos haven't completely replaced the old relationship, just merely changed the exchange. In Hyderabad, Vinitha Venkat sees a version of this between her father, R.V. Venkateswarulu, 83, and their cook Wahida, an Assamese woman in her mid-30s who moved to the city a decade ago. "I've always liked making things. Earlier, it was carpentry, now it's mostly food. I spend a lot of time watching videos and bookmarking things I think the family might enjoy," says Venkateswarulu, who finds recipes online and sends them to Wahida. "These days, I'm always looking for something new to try, especially if it might get my grandson to eat a little more." Wahida, who watches the videos at home, sits with Venkateswarulu the next morning and discusses the recipe – often giving her own suggestions and tweaks – before she starts cooking.



Earlier, I used to ask others how to make a dish. Now people ask me. I never thought anyone would learn from me

RAJESHWARI THAPA
Known online as Raji Didi

The everyday creator Today, domestic cooks are also becoming sources of cooking knowledge themselves. Rajeshwari Mangar Thapa, 35, known online as Raji Didi (@homefoodswithraji; 35k followers on Instagram), started appearing last year in cooking videos made by her

employer, Aishwarya S. Krishnan. The videos showcase simple, healthy home-style meals, where Thapa talks in Hindi about gluten, protein sources such as tempeh, and healthy snack options (air-fried banana chips). Her recipes include everything from the Tibetan noodle soup *thukpa* to a Catalanian Romanesco sauce. "If a nutritionist does the same thing, it will not land with people as well as a home cook does," says Krishnan, 29, founder of Bengaluru-based creative agency True Umami. "People relate to her."

Thapa's first surprise was an Instagram message from another domestic cook who had attempted making one of her dishes at his employer's home. "Earlier, I used to ask others how to make a dish. Now people ask me," she exclaims, adding that her videos gets likes, recipe questions, and plentiful messages from other cooks. Krishnan responds to all the messages, and till date, they haven't tried to monetise the account.

She is part of a broader online trend in which domestic cooks and household workers are becoming visible beyond the homes where they work. In Mumbai, Heena Ali (@heenaali9248; 125k followers) could be called a trendsetter. In 2023, she started building an online following after her employer suggested she record her daily life and cooking videos. Last year, she participated in the *MasterChef India* auditions (where the winner gets ₹25 lakh as prize money). Domestic cook

Who they follow

Many employers compare recipes from different creators before choosing which to send to their cooks. Shroff, for instance, likes Swasthi's Recipes and Archana's Kitchen. But the cooks have their preferences, too. Shubhra Chatterji, a filmmaker in Mumbai, says her cook, Nazia, prefers YouTube over Instagram and looks up videos by Sanjyot Keer, Sanjeev Kapoor, and Ranveer Brar – because the recipes are simple and she wants to see what "master chefs" do differently.



For part-time cooks, digital upskilling can improve employability and gain them a less supervised kitchen, but for live-in workers, it could become another unpaid task

ADITI SURIE
Sociologist

Shorter videos are great for quick explanations, but if the language is unfamiliar, I send a detailed voice note with it. When I noticed him playing the videos again and again, I began sharing screenshots of the steps

SUMAYYA SHARAF
Her cook enjoys the break in routine that new recipes bring

Sapna Jamadar often appears alongside her Mumbai-based employer Praseon Dargarh (@boywhodecorates 267k subscribers), and now wants to establish her own identity on social media.

Celebrities have played a role in giving this trend visibility. Ever since filmmaker Farah Khan's cook Dilip Mukhiya started appearing on her YouTube channel in 2024, the duo's banter has won him fans and

followers. Actor and TV personality Archana Puran Singh's house help Bhagyashri began appearing on her Reels during the pandemic lockdowns. Today, she is surprised to be recognised at events and get asked for selfies.

Taking aglio olio home So, is this shift in how culinary knowledge travels through households making Indian kitchens more multicultural today? Or, is it

helping ease some of the class differences that exist between employer and employee? Social observers say things are still too nascent to draw concrete conclusions. "While it allows cooks and employers to access different cuisines and techniques, it isn't necessarily making Indian kitchens multicultural," says Mehrotra, cautioning against treating this as a simple liberation through YouTube. After all, in India, domestic workers' bargaining power varies sharply by city and region, and caste, community and household control still shape the work. But, she adds, the trend could be "creating the opportunity for that [multiculturalism]".

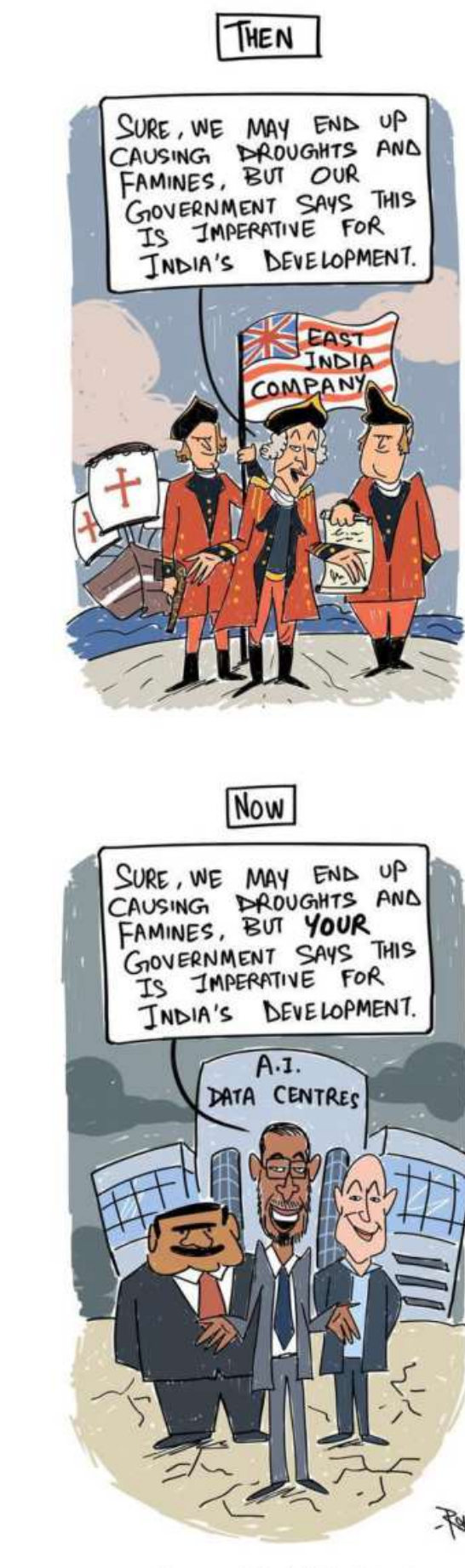
Meanwhile, back in Bengaluru, Tulsi shares that many of the dishes she has learnt at Shah's house are now a part of her own cooking. Pasta is one of them. Recently, after making *aglio olio* for Shah, she swapped the spaghetti and olive oil for a cheaper pack of Sunfeast pasta and regular cooking oil, and prepared the dish at home.

That night, her children sat on the terrace outside their one-room *kholi*, eating pasta with their hands, while her husband ate *dal* and rice. "Mummy, make this every day," they told her. Tulsi laughed as she slowly repeated the unfamiliar name "*aglio olio*", and then convinced her husband to try a bite.

The Bengaluru-based writer is the author of The MTR Story: A Labour of Love.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



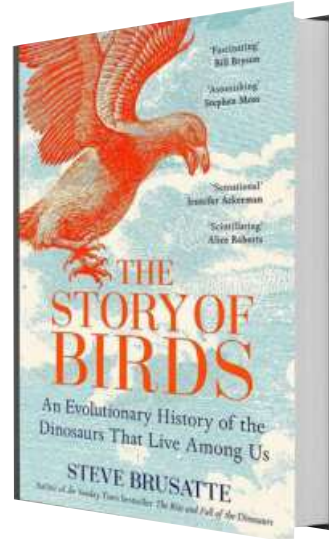
Some of the oldest dinosaurs are Indian, from an era when the subcontinent was wedged into Pangaea. These include the *Rajasaurus*, a homegrown meat-eater nearly the size of a T. Rex. "The destiny is there waiting," says Brusatte

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Roughly once a week, a creature dead for tens of millions of years is introduced to science for the first time. Around 50 new dinosaur species are named every year – a pace the species might have struggled to match even at their peak in the Cretaceous period, between 145 and 66 million years ago. Steve Brusatte, the University of Edinburgh palaeontologist who consults on the *Jurassic World* films and wrote the bestselling *The Rise and Fall of the Dinosaurs* (2018), calls it "a golden age". Brusatte was in Delhi recently – on only his second-ever trip to India – lecturing at the Lodha Genius Programme run by Ashoka University, to high-schoolers he calls "incredibly bright", but with wrinkled optimism. The new discoveries are pouring out of China, Argentina, Brazil, Mongolia and South Africa – the big, fast-growing countries throwing young people at the rocks; however, India is conspicuously under-represented at the dig site, and not for want of fossils, which are "spectacular". Some of the oldest dinosaurs are Indian, from an era when the subcontinent was wedged into Pangaea, when Earth was a single continent, and sitting almost on the South Pole. These include long-necked giants that weighed as much as a Boeing 737, and *Rajasaurus*, a homegrown meat-eater nearly the size of a T.



(Clockwise from left) Steve Brusatte; artistic restorations and a model of the *Rajasaurus*, which was excavated in Gujarat in the 1980s; and Brusatte's new book, (SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR AND WIKI COMMONS)



Rex, plus a celebrated trove of fossilised nests and eggs. "We need more from India," Brusatte says. "The destiny is there waiting" needing only a handful of good students with itchy pickaxes.

Birds on the family tree The bottleneck isn't geology, it is teachers – too few palaeontologists at Indian universities to show the next generation what a fossil even looks like. Moreover, fossils don't only hide in cinematic badlands. Brusatte teaches at a fossil site inside Edinburgh; in China, a near-complete tyrannosaur he later helped describe – *Qianzhousaurus*, nicknamed "Pinocchio rex" for its absurdly long snout – was dug up by construction workers laying a building foundation. Development, it turns out, can also yield fossils. For a country building as fast as

IN CONVERSATION

JURASSIC WORLD IN INDIA?

Palaeontologist Steve Brusatte on why the country could be the world's next dinosaur hotspot

Training 'smart'

As services such as BookMyBai, ChefKart, Cookzy and Urban Company's InstaChef make it easier to book cooks – transforming a deeply personal task into a purely transactional service – outfits are working on bringing trust back into the picture. Jinn, a new cook-booking platform, trains its employees in both cooking and customer preferences before placing them. "Cooking is about making soulful, thoughtful food," says co-founder Mrinal Sharma. "Customers specifically request cooks who make *savvik* food or healthy meals." After registering, prospective cooks are trained in the Jinn kitchen, where recipe videos by chefs such as Nisha Madhulika are part of the training material.

Maharashtra and spilling across Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat and Karnataka – that began a few million years before the asteroid hit. The impact of the asteroid ended the dinosaurs, and scientists have long disputed the cause.

One camp argues the Traps did it, belching climate-wrecking gases that poisoned the air and seas; Brusatte sides with the rival camp. Dinosaurs were thriving right up to the end, he notes. They were found among the very lava flows the early eruptions laid down, until the asteroid with energy exceeding a billion nuclear bombs. The blast vapourised everything for thousands of kilometres, but the real culprit was the aftermath: years of darkness as soot blotted out the sun wrecking food chains. The Deccan eruptions may have piled on, but they didn't pull the trigger, he underlines.

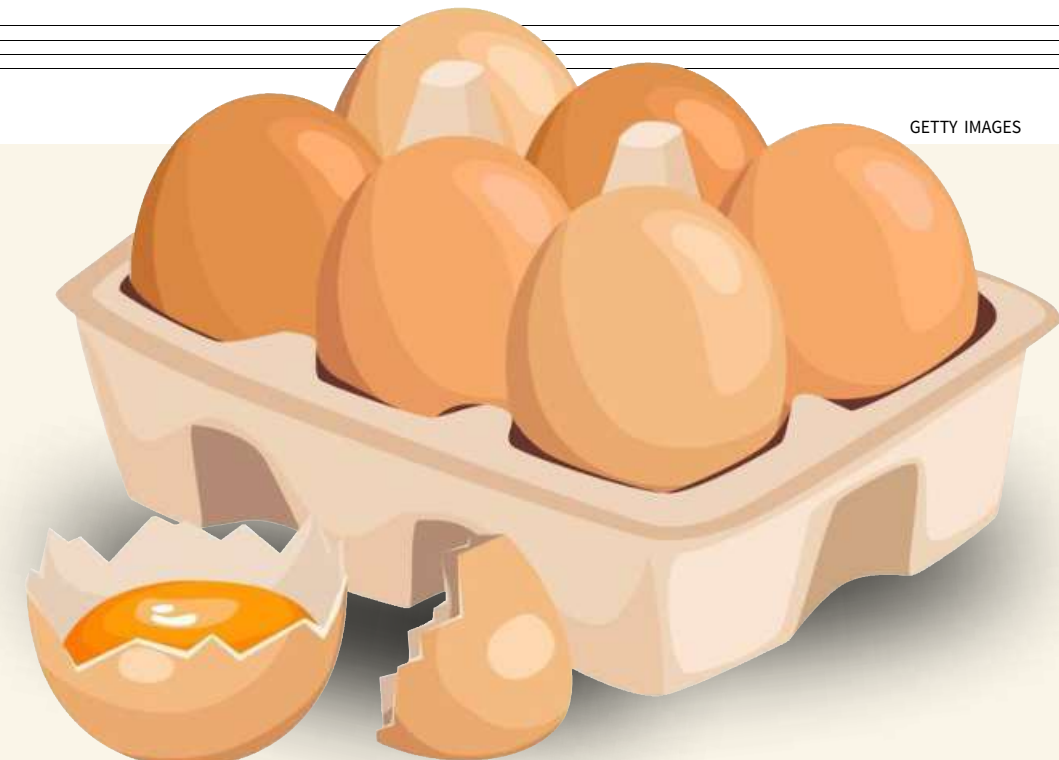
Survival came down to being small, quick and nutritionally indiscriminate: anything bigger than a decent-sized dog was doomed once the larder emptied. The birds that made it were tiny, strong-winged and fast-breeding; the surviving mammals were mouse-sized burrowers. Being big and scary, Brusatte notes drily, became a liability once the rules changed.

What does he say about artificial intelligence that's threatening to make dinosaurs of humans? Brusatte is allergic to the hype, with no wish to see large language models pump out "dop" such as images of dinosaurs with 13 toes and all. But trained tightly, the tools shine. He and Gregor Hartmann, a German computer scientist, have built an algorithm fed only black-and-white silhouettes of footprints from Scotland's Isle of Skye; with no human labels, it worked out how best to sort them. Now, anyone can photograph a track in an app and learn which dinosaurs left its closest cousins. The machine spots the pattern and the human reads the meaning. "The best science is interdisciplinary," he says – but it is also, he'd insist, still mostly about going outside and looking down.



Scan the QR code to watch Steve Brusatte in conversation on magazine.thehindu.com

Survival of the smallest On the asteroid, Brusatte is firm, and India has skin in the game thanks to the Deccan Traps' colossal volcanic eruptions – among Earth's largest, centred on



GETTY IMAGES

POP-A-RAZZI

Summer of the egg

Bengal's *deem*-throwing craze reveals a deeper crisis of trust in politics

programme the government wants to roll out. But the general consensus in Bengal seems to be that you cannot make a new omelette without cracking a few eggs.

A throw to remember It all makes one wonder though about the strange satisfaction we derive in throwing things, snowballs to javelins. Or eggs. In the hunting and gathering times, being able to throw a spear accurately meant there was dinner that night. Slowly, that became less of a necessity but throwing remains baked into many of our sports, from cricket to darts. Accurate high-momentum throwing is a sign of our evolution as a species. Science says a good throw can result in a dopamine rush. Conversely, my inability to catch a ball thrown at me from across the field always made me feel a lesser human. Perhaps, that's why when we throw something at

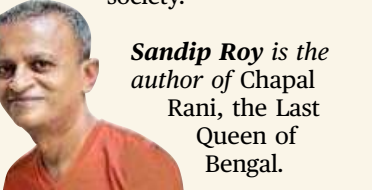
someone powerful and it lands, for a moment, we feel superhuman. In America, frustrated activists often threw pies at politicians. The activity came to be called pie-ing. Famous anti-gay-rights activist Anita Bryant had an aluminium pie-tin filled with banana cream thrown in her face in 1977. Anti-capitalist protesters have pined Bill Gates and economist Milton Friedman. On the other side of the political divide, consumer advocate Ralph Nader and psychedelic evangelist Timothy Leary have gotten pined in their faces. The group Biotic Baking Brigade specialised in this form of protest. It was humorous, relatively non-violent, fed into a sort of David vs. Goliath narrative, and ultimately made the news (and a mess). It was, writes journalist Ben Pynter, an "early political meme". Of course, pies are not the only things we throw to vent

at the powerful. At a press conference in Baghdad in 2008, an Iraqi journalist threw shoes at former U.S. president George W. Bush calling it a "farewell kiss from the Iraqi people". Bush ducked and the journalist went to prison, though hundreds marched in solidarity, carrying shoes attached to poles.

Closer home, Pakistan's Pervez Musharraf and India's Arvind Kejriwal have also had shoes thrown at them. There have been more exotic missiles – banana and salted caramel milkshake at the U.K.'s Reform politician Nigel Farage, condoms filled with purple flour at Tony Blair, and a dildo for New Zealand minister Steven Joyce.

A rotten state But in Bengal, *Deem Therapy* (eggs are called *deem* in Bengali) is playing out like a reality show with a new episode every day. While there is scant sympathy for many of the targets, the glee with which this sport has been embraced proves something is deeply rotten and it's not just the eggs. When legitimate means of protest, from marches to police FIRs to even Instagram and X posts are routinely squashed, the anger doesn't go away. It festers like rotting eggs. Today, the target might be politicians perceived as corrupt, and there is pleasure in seeing the powerful left with egg on their faces. But tomorrow, it could be anyone the mob dislikes – an actor, a writer, a social worker, a freethinker, a protester. Already, a school head-teacher was reportedly "egged" after news emerged of condoms being found in the schoolyard in West Bengal's Malda. And what, in the end, is the *anda ka funda*?

Unfortunately, *deem* therapy, satisfying as it might be in the moment, does not ultimately make for an egg-allitarian society.



Sandip Roy is the author of Chapal Rani, the Last Queen of Bengal.

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 33

LET’S MEET. OR NOT

No greater joy in modern adult existence than when a meeting gets cancelled

Dear readers, last week, on Friday to be precise, I woke up in the morning and looked at my calendar. And lo and behold, I realised that I had only two work meetings to attend throughout the day.

In that instant, a tremendous feeling of joy passed through my body and mind. It was almost a childish feeling of delight. As if it was the first day of school vacation and your father had just announced that he has booked a tempo traveller and the entire extended family is going somewhere on holiday.

And then I looked at my calendar more closely. It turned out that my meetings were at 10 a.m. and 1.30 p.m. Immediately, that childish feeling of delight dissipated. As if it was the first day of school vacation and your father had just announced that he has booked a tempo traveller and the entire extended family is going on

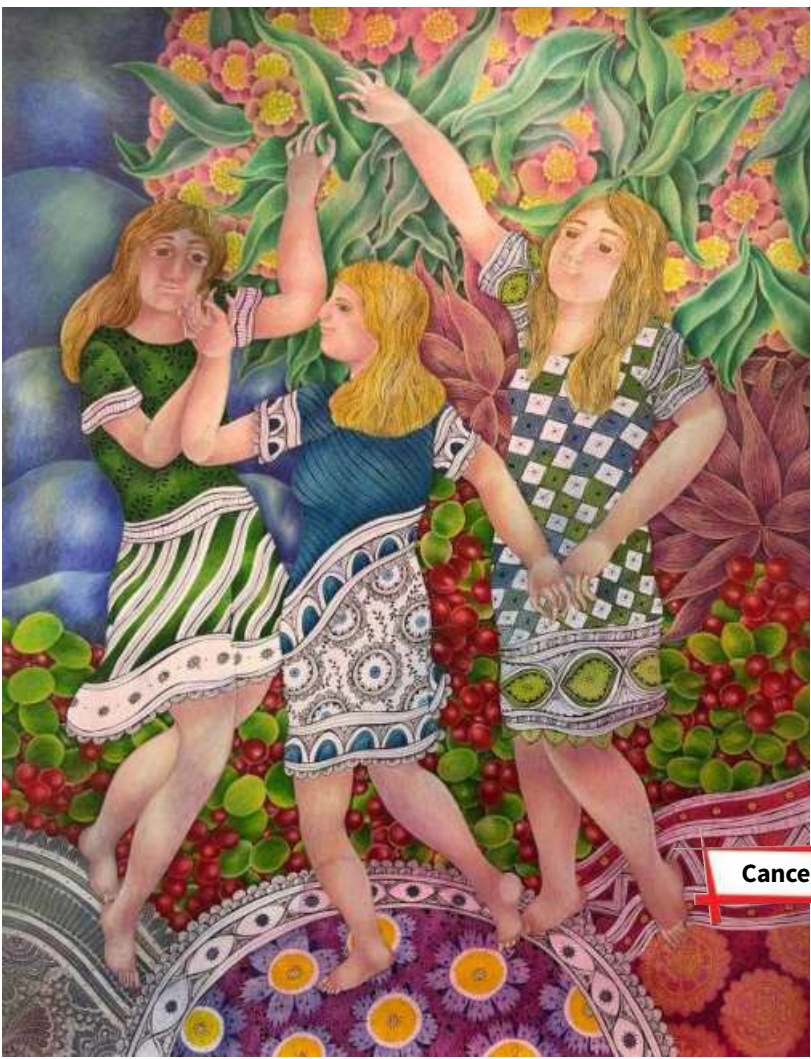
holiday to Kodaikanal for the 55th time in the last six months.

Friends, please explain to me why our parents were obsessed with either Kodaikanal or Mysuru. Perhaps we shall discuss this in another column.

Back to my feeling of consternation. Why was I so disappointed? Let me explain. According to this writer, there are only two ideal ways in which to schedule meetings in your working day. Either you organise them all at once, one after the other, with no more than 15 minutes between them. Or you have none at all.

The most pitiful arrangement of meetings is when you have just two or three, all spaced out by one or two hours in between.

Why? This is because the meetings are neither far apart enough to allow you to do some actual work – such as writing a globally renowned fortnightly column for a major Indian



An untitled (2024) watercolour by Maya Burman. (COURTESY ART ALIVE GALLERY)

newspaper; nor are they close enough for you to just sit at your desk and tick them off one after the other.

Instead, I now have to figure out what to do in the awkward gap between these meetings. Is it long

enough to, for instance, read a book, cook a nice lunch, do some laundry, file your taxes or argue with people on the Internet? Maybe. But only if you do this quickly. Otherwise, you will end up running from the kitchen to

Cancellation
/ˌkænsəlˈeɪʃən/
noun

Definition: The pure, unmatched euphoria experienced when someone cancels a scheduled meeting and, crucially, does not attempt to reschedule it, granting you an unexpected pocket of complete freedom.

Related forms:
Cancelled (*adjective*): Filled with the joy that comes from a permanently cancelled meeting.
Cancelelate (*verb*): To experience joy upon a meeting's cancellation without rescheduling.

your computer because you under-soaked the horse gram and now the pressure cooker needs an extra whistle.

But is it short enough to just sit at your computer and do random amusements? Also no. At this point, you are probably thinking: “Aha! Sidin! I know what you are about to suggest! You want a new word in the English language that describes the particular predicament of having meetings that are separated by awkward intervals of time!”

Wrong. How dare you presume to understand how my mind works? Also, please be patient. Ten minutes or so before my second meeting, suddenly I get a message on my WhatsApp. “Dear Sidin,” it says, “due to unavoidable

circumstances, I will have to cancel our meeting. I hope this is okay?”

“This is fine,” I said. “Let us try and catch up next week when our calendars align.”

My correspondent agreed and then we wished each other a very happy weekend.

Dear readers, what I felt in that moment was the purest form of human delight. Do any of you remember that old advertisement for EsselWorld amusement park in Mumbai, featuring assorted, emotionally uncontrolled children? Now imagine that video playing on loop for 24 hours.

That would still not suffice to capture the glee in my heart.

Readers, there is no greater joy in modern adult existence than the joy you get when someone cancels a meeting, and then also does not reschedule it. And this is a feeling for which we urgently require a word in the English language. And that word is simplicity itself: cancellation.

Example sentence: “When my 4 p.m. call suddenly got cancelled, I felt such intense cancellation that I immediately gave my summer interns actual work to do instead of asking ChatGPT for fake projects.”

Do you like this word? Or do you think you can come up with something better? Shall we jump on a call tomorrow? How about at 4 p.m.? I will cancel shortly.



Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

GOREN BRIDGE

Concise bidding

Both vulnerable.
North deals

Today’s deal comes from the mind of South Florida’s Richard Pavlicek, a great American player, teacher, and writer. It was played, according to Pavlicek, at a tournament in the North Pole. The players were all local residents, but from two different factions that did not always get along and did not speak the same language. South intended to bid two clubs,

Stayman, but the opponents thought he bid seven clubs. The director was called and he ruled that seven clubs was the final contract. The fact that he was from the same faction as East-West had nothing to do with his ruling.

South won the opening heart lead with his 10 and led the 10 of diamonds to the jack and queen. He crossed back to his hand with a heart to the queen and led the 10 of spades to the jack and queen. So far, so good. South led a heart to his ace and

led the nine of diamonds, winning the trick. The nine of spades was next, also winning the trick. Declarer now led a club to dummy’s nine and won that trick also! He cashed the ace of spades and the ace of diamonds with both opponents following suit to everything. He ruffed dummy’s last spade with the king of clubs as both opponents under-ruffed. Dummy had to take the last two tricks with the ace-jack of clubs and the grand slam rolled home! A beauty!

NORTH
♠ A Q 3 2
♥ 5 4 3
♦ A Q 3
♣ A J 9

WEST
♠ K J 6
♥ 9 8 7
♦ K J 6
♣ Q 10 8 7

EAST
♠ 7 5 4
♥ K J 6
♦ 7 5 4
♣ 6 5 4 3

SOUTH
♠ 10 9 8
♥ A Q 10 2
♦ 10 9 8 2
♣ K 2

The bidding:
NORTH INT
EAST Pass
SOUTH 7♣
WEST All pass

Opening lead: Nine of ♥

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

It’s a doggy dog world!



The Komondor was bred for a very specific purpose. Its thick, corded coat protects it from wolf bites and helps it blend in with the animals it guards. (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

1 Born on June 28, 1852, Charles Cruft was an English showman who worked for Spratt’s, a manufacturer of pet food. He travelled around Britain showcasing pets and, in 1891, launched an event named after him. What is Crufts, the largest event of its kind in the world?

2 In 1917, the British Kennel Club officially changed the name of this popular dog breed to ‘Alsatian Wolf Dog’, reflecting the sentiment during World War I. In 1977, it went back to its original name, which references the work the breed was developed to do. Which breed is this?

3 Tihar is a five-day festival, the second day of which, Kukur

Tihar, is devoted to dogs. It celebrates the deep bond between humans and dogs, recognising their loyalty and companionship. Which country, where the Bikram Sambat calendar is widely used, celebrates this festival?

4 These popular pet birds derive their name from an island off the coast of Africa where they were first encountered by Europeans. The island’s name is believed to mean ‘Island of the Dogs’. Which birds, once used by miners to detect toxic gases, are these?

5 The Great ____ is the third-highest road pass in Switzerland. A hospice for travellers was established there in the 11th century, and the

monks much later worked on a breed of large working dog for rescue operations in the Alps. What is the name of the pass?

6 Rin Tin Tin was a German Shepherd rescued from a World War I battlefield and trained as an actor. He went on to star in 27 films. In 1929, Jack Warner reportedly included his name in discussions for Best Actor in the inaugural edition of which iconic awards ceremony?

7 This dog breed’s name means ‘badger dog’ in German, reflecting its original purpose of hunting badgers, rabbits and foxes in burrows. Its long ears help keep dirt out, its curved tail acts as a signal, and its short legs aid manoeuvrability underground. Which breed is this?

8 This Commander-in-Chief had a lifelong association with dogs and even developed a new strain of foxhound. On October 6, 1777, during the American Revolutionary War, a small terrier wandered between the American and British lines. When it was discovered that the dog belonged to a British general, the commander ordered its safe return behind enemy lines under a flag of truce. Who was this man, who later became the first of 45 so far in the U.S.?

9 A study in Moscow highlighted the remarkable behaviour of a pack of stray dogs. The pressures of urban life appear to have driven them to master a human transport system. These dogs travel daily, learn routes, recognise regular passengers, and know when to get off. What mode of transport do they use?

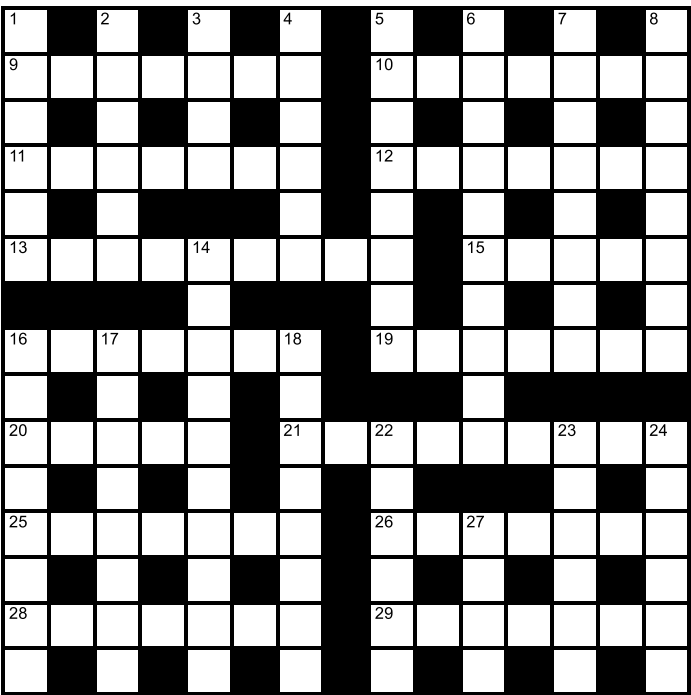
10 The Komondor was bred for a very specific purpose. Its thick, corded coat protects it from wolf bites and helps it blend in with the animals it guards. Which animal was this breed originally developed to protect?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

- 1. Dog show
- 2. German Shepherd
- 3. Nepal
- 4. Canary
- 5. St. Bernard
- 6. The Academy Awards (Oscars)
- 7. Dachshund
- 8. George Washington
- 9. The subway
- 10. Sheep

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 62 (Set by Arden)

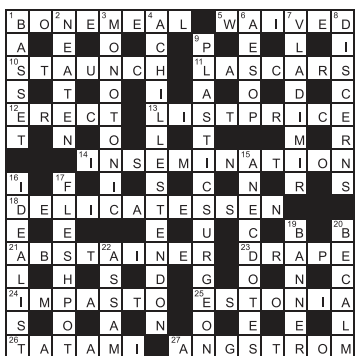


- Across**
- 9** A book on coffee — review gets backing (7)
 - 10** Point to follow — Harry and you, find some capital (7)
 - 11** Slight shortage in hormone (7)
 - 12** Boy describes map of Northern Finland (7)
 - 13** Intended to raise, stole a vehicle (9)
 - 15** Aversion for a cricket match — strange to get run out (5)
 - 16** Haunt as hood grabs a part (7)
 - 19** Taken in by a small glove (7)
 - 20** Caught in a dire situation — it’s rock bottom (5)
 - 21** Resolve matter, or block departure from port (9)
 - 25** Plant loaded only on west-bound donkey (7)
 - 26** The elderly accommodated in a big room with luggage (7)
 - 28** See love rejected — it’s not a pretty sight (7)
 - 29** Copying model on the tracks, say (7)

- Down**
- 1** America in a mess — set up somewhat by a crazy guy (6)
 - 2** Drinks beer regularly in a promotional video (6)
 - 3** Part of retaliation among others (2,2)
 - 4** Scientist’s design check — ignoring insiders (6)

- 5** Spins around 2 Greek islands (8)
- 6** Give and take income — dance is held (10)
- 7** Girl’s inclination for a historian (8)
- 8** Macho males eat radish regularly and keep an eye on their stock (8)
- 14** A torn piece of electrical machinery? (10)
- 16** German city acquiring middle age relic (8)
- 17** Harried for special grade lying down (8)
- 18** Nips yield (8)
- 22** It comes up around a very popular place in South Pacific (6)
- 23** Consists of two parts — dreamy and idyllic from all sides... (6)
- 24** ...Informal again in the south of Spain (6)
- 27** Lift bar for a teller of tales (4)

SOLUTION NO. 61



An unusual aspiration for a young student

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When I was in the eighth standard, a teacher of mine asked students of my class what they liked to become when they grew up. One boy wanted to become a doctor, another wanted to become a police officer, and yet another wanted to become a soldier. When I stood up and revealed what I was dreaming to become when I grew up – a goods train guard – my teacher was shocked while the other boys booed. After silencing the boys who naturally thought my choice was funny, my teacher wanted to know why I chose to become a goods train guard. “What you will ultimately end up as is a different matter but as a young boy you should aim high,” he said. I hesitantly replied, “Sir, I want to become a goods train guard because I like the goods train guard’s cabin so much.”

My classmate Viswanath stood up and said, “Sir I know why he chose to become a goods train guard. He is slow and goods trains are slow. He holds the last rank in the class and naturally he likes the last wagon that is the guard’s cabin.”

The entire class endorsed his explanation by bursting into laughter.

We lived in a house near a railway line. Trains became a part of our lives. I never failed to look at trains as they pass by hardly a furlong away from our window. Though I liked passenger trains a lot, it was the goods trains that won my heart. A goods train is slow, graceful, and unhurried and humble. What in a goods train that I really fell for is its last cosy cabin for the guard. Since its position is far from the train’s noisy engines, it has a serene air about itself.

Most of the children those days yearned to have an opportunity to travel in the driver’s cabin. But I longed to be allowed to travel in the guard’s cabin. I was dying to know what it would feel like to travel in it when it rains outside, through the countryside, looking at fields, trees, hills rolling in the distance, and undulating lush green meadows dotted with grazing cows. Above all, the balcony-like open space of the cabin with steel hand railings, standing from which guards wave their green flag to the stationmasters, is wonderful. I longed to sit in the guard cabin and watch the star-spangled night sky with a silver sickle of a moon, through unpolluted clean and clear air, while the goods train was taking a nap at some signal in the countryside.

The sad part of this love story is this: I got a stifling bank cashier cabin when I grew up. Even now I feel a twinge of pain in my heart whenever I see the guard’s cabin of a passing goods train.



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Court after court in India has been giving directives to abolish the orderly system that employs police personnel for household duties of higher or even retired police officers. These rulings are a victory for the dignity of lower-ranked personnel, while leading to a significant transition for senior officers and their families who have been traditionally relying on this system.

For so long, apart from those in the police and the Army, an orderly or peon had roles that often blurred the lines between their official duties and personal service to the superiors and their families, particularly within the revenue and other administrative departments of the government. The qualifications for these workers were focused only on functional literacy, reliability, and manual skills rather than higher academic achievements.

While official job descriptions lay emphasis on routine official tasks, in practice, these roles have historically included domestic chores, errands of family members, and private assistance such as gardening, walking the dog or ferrying children to school, stemming from a deeply entrenched hierarchical culture.

The custom of providing high-ranking officers such as Collectors with orderlies or bungalow peons continues to this day. During an inspection of a public project by an officer, his accompanying peon with a red turban, belt or sash would add a distinct and disciplined image to the official engagement. These official assistants are intended primarily to help manage the officials’ home office and errands, which extend to personal tasks.

The practice of having domestic help in India has deep historical roots in the ancient hierarchical structure, evolving from a combination of caste-based duties and traditional servitude. Large retinues of servants were common in royal households. Much later, intense colonial influences institutionalised domestic services. According to Shashi Tharoor, in the

A future without household help

Finding reliable household help will become increasingly difficult in the days to come with rising education levels and economic development, creating a significant supply-demand gap

early days of the British rule, wives of European officials were waited upon by “a flotilla of servants”. These included ayahs (maids) and male bearers and butlers. In the early 20th century, Western homes particularly in Britain and America underwent a significant shift from relying on live-in domestic workers to managing without them. The transition was driven more by economic shifts, changing social attitudes, and, most notably, the rapid rise of labour-saving technology.

The introduction of new household appliances enabled fewer people to do more work. These included vacuum cleaners, washing machines, gas stoves, and electric ovens and irons. The First World War played a significant part in the transition.

Despite the decline of domestic workers in Britain during the early 20th century, India experienced a boom with the 1931 Census showing a high concentration of workers in domestic service, particularly in cities such as Kolkata, Mumbai, and Chennai. Those were days of joint families where there were generations of workers who served the same lineage.

Later, elite urbanites employed several helpers: maids, cooks, cleaners, ironers, and drivers. There was at least one helper in each household. For many years now, a common sight in towns and villages is the house-to-house visit of maids early in the mornings, often before

daybreak to sweep, mop, and draw *Kolam*, the design drawn using rice flour in the front of houses as a part of daily routine. Domestic help had become almost indispensable.

Unorganised, undocumented Employing an estimated 50 million to 90 million people, the Indian domestic helper market caters to every urban household while remaining unorganised and undocumented. The present outlook suggests that finding reliable household help will become increasingly difficult in the days to come due to rising education levels and economic development, creating a significant supply-demand gap. The future domestic work market will be characterised by higher costs, higher requirements for professional training, and increased reliance on technology to bridge the gap.

Police households where assistance of orderlies has been discontinued could get alternative government-aided or private arrangements. However, eventually self-help should be the best policy to be adopted not only by these households, but by all, by embracing minimalism and modern appliances. Indians living abroad have already adopted it. All that is required is significant planning, simplification of lifestyle, and team effort. Managing without help can increase self-dependence and lead to a more organised personal space.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

AI tools are genuinely democratising UPSC preparation, particularly for aspirants who cannot afford expensive Delhi-based coaching. (‘The great coaching disruption’; June 21) Institutes must reinvent themselves as mentoring hubs, combining AI’s reach with human judgment.

A. Myilsami

Tough break

It is sad that we are unable to produce a football team that could qualify to play the World Cup. (‘Why is India not in the World Cup?’; June 21) The culprit is cricket, which has gained undue prominence across the country. Hockey, football, table tennis, basketball et al are finding it extremely difficult to make a headway in the nation.

K. Pradeep

Technology is a boon in disguise for UPSC aspirants. Parents have to no longer spend enormous amounts for coaching classes. But at the end of the day, live teaching and interactive classes are more impactful.

Ratna Naidu

Insightful read

The conversation on Romila Thapar’s book *Just Being*, and on the rise of Hindutva, was enlightening. (‘Nehruvian elite not responsible for rise of Hindutva’; June 21) Her logical argument as to why the Nehruvian elite cannot be faulted for the rise of Hindutva is convincing.

Kosaraju Chandramouli

Travelling to Antarctica

Rising tourist numbers in Antarctica raise questions about the future of this fragile ecosystem, which is already threatened by carbon emissions, climate change, and over-fishing. (‘Journey to the end of the world’; June 21) Although eco-friendly tour operators and biosecurity measures have become more common in recent years, increasing awareness about the threats facing the region remains crucial.

Monita Sutherson

Cultural bridge

Devdutt Pattanaik’s column beautifully illustrates how stories transcend borders and languages. (‘The parrot that flew to Baghdad’; June 21) The parallels between the Sanskrit *Sukasaptati* and *One Thousand and One Nights* remind us that civilisations have long enriched one another through cultural exchange.

Harsh Pawaria

Making history

This photo exhibition not only showcases the brilliance of Nemat Ghosh, it also narrates the history of Bengali literature and cinema. (‘Ray at work’; June 21) The photo taken on the set of *Ghare Baire* is unique as it captures Satyajit Ray’s passion for his work.

Rashmi P.

Correction

In the article titled ‘The great coaching disruption’ (June 21), Shubhangi Singh should have been described as part of the Vajiram & Ravi team, and not as mentioned. The error is regretted.

— Editor



MORE ON THE WEB

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The gift of reading

The best thing about good books is they guide you towards the person you wish to become

Sujatha Rao

Students fear irrelevance, not failure

They are forced to be full-time brand manager for themselves

Abhijna Laxmi

Restorative architecture: ideals vs reality

It’s about a mindset that allows room for the unplanned challenges and joys of living with nature

Amita Basu

In death’s shadow

Courage is continuing to participate in life even when constantly bombarded with images of horrible deaths

Chanchala Borah

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Jairam N. Menon

I belong to the overlooked and sadly undervalued tribe of music aficionados who cannot sing a song. But since I have no wish to deprive the world of my latent and unexpressed musical offerings, I do the next best: I hum. I have a wide repertoire and my all-weather range straddles multiple ragas and covers all the emotions – happy, sad, and in-between.

Humming, I believe, is music in its embryonic form. It is the fledgling that flaps its hesitant wings on the ledge before stepping out to etch its signature on the sky. Contrast this modest restraint and tentative tone with the assertive rasp of a full-bodied song.

Onerous tasks

Singing also calls for much heavy lifting – like getting up when the world sleeps and shaking the neighbourhood out of its stupor with a *sadhna* or *riyaz*. It involves preparatory steps such as locating a guru compatible with your voice and wallet, achieving rhythmic control through trial and terror, testing the mike, formally clearing your throat and so on. As if all this was not enough, they also expect you to

Humming is for everyone

It’s democracy written in with musical notations



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

congenitally and contagiously tone-deaf. It’s democracy written in with musical notations. Untethered to any canon and undeterred by convention, it can be as unabashedly self-expressive as bathroom singing minus mug in hand or shower overhead.

When you embark on a formal song, you need to pay attention to what you are wearing. It would perhaps call for a set *mundu* or silk shirt and *veshti* or black tie. With humming, any old T-shirt and old jeans will do. Also, singers need to closely follow the lyrics.

Random inspiration

The best of them focus on a sheet in front of them or their mobile screen. With humming, you are not tied down by the words someone else has penned down. Instead, you let yourself be air-borne by what Wordsworth described as the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings. You can hum about anything under the sun – snatches of random songs, faraway remembrances or the things that happened once-upon-a dream.

Unfortunately, as things stand there are not any contests or awards which recognise and reward those who hum best. But that shouldn’t bother you. When



Humming to yourself is recognised by therapists as a catalyst for personal well-being. It does wonders for the vagus nerve which soothes the parasympathetic nervous system and calms you

music has been snatched from the hands of a privileged few and the password has been shared with the rest of the world. Humming is for everyone, even the

possess talent. Phew!

Yet, across all of recorded history, it’s been singers who have ruled the roost. Feted by profligate award juries and egged on by the chatterati, they believe they hold a global patent on glory. But flying under the radar is our wordless melody that can upstage the top of the pops because of its ease of access.

Look at it this way. Traditional music is the auditory equivalent of an oh-so-exclusive gated community that leaves most of us on the outside looking in. Now, those entry barriers have been pulled down. The gift of



(Clockwise from left) Photos shot in Sewri, 2013; Kalwa, 2024; and Cotton Green, 2024; photographer Sunhil Sippy; *EASTWARD* at Galerie Mirchandani + Steinruecke; and dock workers at Darukhana, 2013. (COURTESY SUNHIL SIPPY)

SUNHIL SIPPY'S VANISHING MUMBAI

The photographer's first solo exhibition distils years of walking the eastern seafront, recording a side of the city that is rapidly slipping from view

Reshmi Chakraborty

Mangroves under threat of vanishing along Mumbai's eastern seafront, salt pans stretching across the horizon that may soon give way to housing societies. Photographer Sunhil Sippy's first solo exhibition, *EASTWARD: Explorations Along Mumbai's Eastern Seaboard*, documents a lesser-seen part of the city, giving visitors a sense of beauty in decay and the resilience of nature. Many of the exhibition's images depict spaces in transition; landscapes suspended between abandonment and development. "I wish there was a bench to sit there for an hour and feel it," theatre actor Sanjana Kapoor told Sippy after visiting the exhibition. Others have called the images "haunting". Much of the

reaction to this stark yet deeply human body of work lies in how Sippy approached the archive and its curation. The show is the result of a journey with no theme or agenda in mind. His images were shot over 12 years without a fixed plan, accumulating gradually through repeated returns to the eastern seaboard – the final project, *Eastward*, emerging retrospectively rather than by design. What strikes first is how differently Sippy shoots Mumbai. The images are raw, the resilience of nature taking over decay a resonant one – trees coil around crumbling structures, roots penetrate concrete, and mangroves persist at the edge of urban expansion. Yet, the human element, of labour in the margins of a constantly moving city, is never far from the frame, reminding us that these too are inhabited spaces.

Breaking free of the studio Sippy comes from Bollywood pedigree. He is the grandson of producer G.P. Sippy (think *Sholay*). He admits that while his western style of storytelling probably did not work in the early 2000s when he made his debut feature film *Snipt!*, its visual language helped him transition to advertising, where he remains much in demand. His commissions include ongoing archival work for designer Sabyasachi Mukherjee, Chatterjee & Lal, and the Film Heritage Foundation. Sippy grew up in London and would visit industrial sites connected to his family's steel business during childhood. He remembers the visual intensity of those environments – furnaces, heat, fire and cranes. When he returned decades later, he found abandoned, decaying spaces instead. The contrast between memory and present neglect heightened his



interest in time and fragility. But the photographs in the show are not attempts to visualise personal memories. Like his two photobooks, *The Opium of Time* (2022; an exploration of life on Mumbai's streets) and *RACEDAY* (2026; a decade-long documentation of Mahalaxmi Racecourse), *Eastward* is the work of a flâneur intuitively observing his muse: Mumbai. His photography journey, he shares, was born partly as a reaction to the arrival of the digital format. The shift from 35mm film to digital monitors allowed clients and agencies to scrutinise and influence the creative process on set, diminishing the chain of trust that once existed between director and cinematographer. "I was shooting in the most constructed atmosphere. With the most perfect light, the most perfect everything," he says. "But when it came to my moment, after everyone had set up theirs, I wasn't getting time to craft a narrative." He began walking the streets of Mumbai as a response to the controlled environment of the studio. "I needed to break out of that environment," he says. A brutal accident while shooting a road safety commercial in Noida in 2012 became the inflection point for the final shift. "It took multiple surgeries and six months before I could properly wear a shoe again. Walking was extremely painful, but it was the

only thing that was going to heal me. That's when I really started taking photography much more seriously." **A living, unfinished process** *Eastward* arrives at a moment when much of the eastern seaboard stands on the cusp of transformation. New infrastructure links are connecting Mumbai's eastern and western halves. For Sippy, however, the issue is not development itself. "It's how they get developed," he says. Yet, his photographs are not literal documentations. Instead, they function as silent witnesses. "It is an impressionistic recording of a time; it is not message-driven," he says. What is important for the archivist is how the city is revealed and the many layers viewers are free to experience on their own. He has revisited these images over years, only printing those he is repeatedly drawn to, even if they were initially considered imperfect. Sippy has now been walking the eastern edge of Mumbai for years, returning repeatedly to the salt pans, shipyards and abandoned factories. The process has brought a sense of time and quietness to the way he presents the work, even in images of dockyard workers walking to work in what would, in reality, be a chaotic bustle. "For me, photography is a meditative practice," he says. Sippy works with a Hasselblad SWC that doesn't have a viewfinder. "You hold it and observe. And it's magical because you just see the space with your eyes, you feel the environment. You don't frame it, you click the shutter and let go. There's a sense of surrender." He scans the negatives himself, the resulting image often a beautiful discovery of trusting his camera, perhaps harking back to the pre-digital era trust that once existed between director and cinematographer.

EASTWARD is on view at Galerie Mirchandani + Steinruecke, Fort, Mumbai, till July 15.

The writer is a freelance journalist and the co-author of Rethink Ageing.

Many years ago, on a mild May afternoon, I walked towards Phuphee's kitchen expecting her usual warm welcome. But on that particular day, I saw her outside standing over a *kanz* (a large mortar made of rock) with a *muhul* (a long pestle made from wood) in her hand, pounding away as if her life depended on it. I waited in silence for her to look up, but she didn't. So, I walked into the kitchen where Aisha, Phuphee's household help, raised her eyes from the *daan* and greeted me. She took my bags and asked me to sit down. She poured a hot cup of *kehwe* from a large samovar and served it with some *sheermaal* (a savoury biscuit). I sat there eating and drinking, quietly wondering what Phuphee was up to. Aisha must have noticed me glancing out the window, so she said, 'Aem nyu dilas pyeth [she has taken it to heart].' I asked her what Phuphee had taken to heart. Aisha got up from the *daan*, poured herself a cup of *kehwe* and sat next to me. She narrated the awful story of Sameena. Sameena was a woman who lived in the village. She had been diagnosed with a life-limiting illness. Unfortunately, she didn't have very long left, maybe a few more months if she was lucky. She had three children, the youngest not yet 10 and the eldest still in secondary school. She lived with her husband, his parents and her children. Aisha explained that Sameena now kept mostly to her bed. The illness and the treatments had completely drained her of energy. She spent most of her time sleeping. Phuphee would go and see her from time to time, and take nourishing little treats to tempt her appetite. But Sameena would take a few small



ILLUSTRATION: ZANAB TANBAWALLA

A LITTLE LIFE

Phuphee and the chilli cakes

In this Kashmiri village, what began as a recipe became a lesson nobody forgot

bites and leave the rest. A few days ago, Phuphee had gone to see her and had come back furious. Apparently, Sameena's mother-in-law had asked Phuphee if she had any 'prospective brides' in mind for her son, to which Phuphee had replied, 'He already has a wife'. The mother-in-law had explained that she was an old woman now (referring to herself) and couldn't be expected to raise three young children and look after everything else, including a dying woman. 'Besides,' she had added, 'my son needs a woman to take care of him.'

Phuphee had tried to keep calm, but with every single syllable that came out of the woman's mouth, her patience waned. She had got up and before walking out, said to the old woman, 'A fire warms your home. Show it the respect it deserves. You should wait till the fire dies out on its own. Let the embers cool and turn to ashes before you light a new fire. If you light too many fires at once, you will burn your house down.' When she had come home, she had wept. When she could weep no more, Phuphee had instructed

every single household help to gather ingredients for *vaer*. (The spiced cake is made from pounding together red chillies, garlic, shallots and whole spices. Mustard oil is added to the thick paste and left to ferment before being moulded into cakes and left to dry for a couple of days. It is used throughout the year to season dishes from simple fried eggs to meat or vegetables.) 'You know she only makes *vaer* when she feels like she is at the end of the road, when she feels helpless,' Aisha said, sighing. For the couple of days I was

her eyes. I asked Aisha later what had become of Sameena and if her husband had married again. Sameena had passed away in July, she told me, but her mother-in-law hadn't gone ahead with trying to find a new bride for her son. Upon hearing this, my ears twitched and I blurted out, 'Did Phuphee cast a spell on the old woman?' Aisha smiled and said she didn't know anything about a spell, but Phuphee did send the old woman every single *vaer* she had made. 'You know what that means, don't you?' Aisha asked. 'What?' I replied. Aisha lowered her lips to my ears and whispered, 'When she sends a *vaer*, it is a warning.' 'I cannot say anymore,' she continued. 'I really don't want to spend the rest of my days as a goat or a worm.' And with that, she went back to her chores. I asked Phuphee later if it was true. Had she really sent the *vaer* as a warning? She looked at me amused. 'I don't know what you are talking about. I wish I was half as powerful as you believe me to be *myoan zuv* [my life], but unfortunately, I am not,' she said, sighing and then continuing to smoke her two cigarettes, drawing the breath deep into her lungs. When she had finished, she got up, but before disappearing into the corridor, she turned around and said, 'But maybe being misunderstood in some situations isn't such a terrible thing!'

Saba Mahjoor, a Kashmiri living in England, spends her scant free time contemplating life's vagaries.

